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SAT • EXAM PREP

The Digital SAT Bible — Format, Scoring & Strategy

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A AskSia THE COMPLETE SAT BIBLE · DIGITAL SAT

The Digital SAT

– one exam, every section, every rule, every mark

The Complete SAT Bible

Digital SAT

6 sections

The Digital SAT is a college-admissions test delivered on screen in the College Board's Bluebook app. There are 98 questions, of which 90 are scored and 8 are unscored pretest questions.

- **How the SAT is assessed** Total score 400 to 1600 · Sections and modules 2 sections · 4 modules · Reading and Writing 64 min · 54 questions
- **Key terms** Section, Module, Multistage adaptive testing (MST), Operational question
- **How to study for the SAT** Treat the SAT as a machine to master before you drill a single question, because on an adaptive, digital, no-penalty test the format costs as many points as the content.

• SAT FAQ How long is the Digital SAT?

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CONTENTS · THE WHOLE EXAM, ONE MAP

What the SAT covers

The whole exam → one map. Two sections, eight content domains, 90 scored questions. Reading and Writing first, then a 10-minute break, then Math. Each section links to its free guide.

- | | |
|--|--|
| 1A SAT Reading & Writing: Comprehension & Inference | The reading half of Section 1: comprehension, command of evidence, and inference across short passages. Part of the Reading and Writing section, scored 200 to 800. |
| 1B SAT Reading & Writing: Grammar & Expression | The writing half of Section 1: Standard English conventions and expression of ideas, the most rule-driven points on the test. |
| 02 Math | Section 2. Two 22-question modules, 70 minutes, scored 200 to 800. Four content domains, split across the three guides below. A calculator is allowed on all of Math, with a 12-item reference sheet on screen throughout. |
| 2A SAT Math: Algebra & Advanced Math | Linear equations, systems and inequalities, plus nonlinear functions, quadratics and polynomials. Together about 70% of the Math score, so they earn the most prep time. |
| 2B SAT Math: Problem-Solving & Data Analysis | Ratios, rates and proportions, percentages, units, probability and reading data from tables and graphs. The applied, real-world quantitative domain. |
| 2C SAT Math: Geometry & Trigonometry | Lines, angles and triangles, area and volume, circles, and right-triangle trigonometry. The smallest Math domain, often the most formula-driven. |

It is a 2-section, 4-module adaptive test scored from 400 to 1600, with two sections, Reading and Writing and Math, each scored 200 to 800. The whole test is 2 hours 14 minutes of testing time (64 minutes for Reading and Writing and 70 minutes for Math), plus a single 10-minute break between the two sections.

What makes the Digital SAT different from the old paper test is its format: it is shorter, adaptive, digital and has no penalty for wrong answers, so you should answer every question. The second module of each section adjusts to your performance on the first, and you work with on-screen tools (a built-in timer, the Desmos calculator on all of Math, annotation and flagging).

This overview maps the whole exam: how it is structured and timed, how it is scored, how the adaptive design works, what each section tests, and how to spend every minute. Master the machine here, then master the content in each section guide.

HOW IT IS ASSESSED

How the SAT is assessed

Every figure below is source-verified against the official College Board specification (Assessment Framework v3.01). Confirm the current structure, timing and tools on the official College Board test

specifications before you rely on them.

Total score	400 to 1600	The two sections add to the total. Each section, Reading and Writing and Math, is scored 200 to 800.
Sections and modules	2 sections · 4 modules	Two sections, each split into two equal-length timed modules. You finish all of Reading and Writing, take a 10-minute break, then do all of Math.
Reading and Writing	64 min · 54 questions	Two modules of 27 questions, 32 minutes each. 50 of the 54 are scored; pacing is about 1.2 minutes per question.
Math	70 min · 44 questions	Two modules of 22 questions, 35 minutes each. 40 of the 44 are scored; pacing is about 1.6 minutes per question.
Adaptive design (MST)	Routed once per section	Your performance on Module 1 routes you into a Module 2 that is, on average, easier or harder. The test adapts once per section, not question by question, and the two sections adapt independently.
Guessing penalty	None	There is no penalty for wrong answers, so you should answer every question.

WORKED EXAMPLE · FREE

Use the on-screen Reference Sheet to plan section time

Q. Math has two modules of 22 questions in 35 minutes each. If you want to keep about 5 minutes in reserve at the end of a module to review flagged questions, what is your target average pace per question for the first part of the module? (Work it the way you would budget time on test day.)

- Step 1** Start from the source-verified facts: each Math module is 35 minutes for 22 questions, which is about 1.6 minutes per question if you used the whole time evenly.
- Step 2** Set aside the reserve. Keep 5 minutes back to review flagged items, so plan to work the questions in 35 minus 5 = 30 minutes.
- Step 3** Divide the working time by the question count: 30 minutes over 22 questions is about 1.36 minutes, roughly 1 minute 22 seconds per question.
- Step 4** Bank time on the easy front-of-module questions (they run roughly easiest to hardest) so the hard ones at the back are not rushed, and use the on-screen timer to check you are on pace.

Target about 1 minute 22 seconds per question for the first pass, leaving a 5-minute review reserve. Because there is no guessing penalty, never leave a question blank.

Sia tip — on an adaptive, no-penalty test the format costs as many points as the content. Pace by the module clock, answer every question, flag and move on when stuck, and learn the 12-item math Reference Sheet and the Desmos calculator before test day so the tools are reflex, not a surprise.

Key terms

Section

One of the two scored parts of the Digital SAT: Reading and Writing, and Math. Each section is scored 200 to 800, and the two add to the 400 to 1600 total.

Module

One of the two equal-length parts of a section. Each section has two modules, for four modules in total. The break sits between the two sections, not between modules.

Multistage adaptive testing (MST)

The Digital SAT's adaptive model. Your performance on the first module of a section routes you into a second module that is, on average, easier or harder. The test adapts once per section, and the two sections adapt independently.

Operational question

A scored question that counts toward your section score: 50 in Reading and Writing and 40 in Math, for 90 scored in total.

Pretest question

An unscored question embedded to be field-tested for future exams. There are 8 in total, 4 in each section, so the test has 98 questions but only 90 count.

Student-produced response (SPR)

A Math question where you type the answer directly rather than choosing from options. Fractions or decimals are accepted, with no percent sign, dollar sign or commas.

Reference Sheet

The 12-item math formula sheet available on screen for the whole Math section. Knowing the list, and its gaps, wins time.

Bluebook

The College Board testing app in which the Digital SAT is delivered. It provides a built-in timer, the Desmos calculator, annotation and question flagging.

FAQ

SAT FAQ

► How long is the Digital SAT?

► How many questions are on the Digital SAT?

► How is the Digital SAT scored?

► What does adaptive mean on the Digital SAT?

► Is there an essay on the Digital SAT?

STUDY STRATEGY

How to study for the SAT

Treat the SAT as a machine to master before you drill a single question, because on an adaptive, digital, no-penalty test the format costs as many points as the content. (1) Learn the structure cold: two sections, each split into two timed modules, Reading and Writing first, then a 10-minute break, then Math. Knowing what is coming removes test-day surprises.

(2) Pace by the module clock: Reading and Writing is about 1.2 minutes per question and Math about 1.6, so bank seconds on the easy front-of-module items (questions run roughly easiest to hardest) to protect the hard ones at the back. (3) Answer every question. There is no guessing penalty, so never leave a blank, and flag-and-move when you are stuck rather than burning the clock.

(4) Understand the adaptive design so you do not panic: the second module is routed once per section based on your first module, the two sections adapt independently, and adaptive equating keeps the 200 to 800 scale fair whichever Module 2 you see.

(5) Make the tools reflex before test day: practise in the real Bluebook app, learn the 12-item math Reference Sheet and where it has gaps, and get fluent with the Desmos calculator, the timer, annotation and flagging.

(6) Then build the content: Reading and Writing has four domains (Craft and Structure, Information and Ideas, Standard English Conventions, Expression of Ideas) and Math has four (Algebra, Advanced Math, Problem-Solving and Data Analysis, Geometry and Trigonometry), with Algebra and Advanced Math together about 70% of the Math score, so they earn the most prep time.

(7) Confirm the current structure, timing, tools and score-release windows on the official College Board specifications before you rely on any figure.

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Exam Sections

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